

such services. If you understand that part, you could guess the power dynamics between the two sides.

As the age-old gag in the business goes, the true differences between buy side and sell side is that if you're on the buy side, you can yell obscenities before you hang up the phone. The buy side includes the hedge fund industry, and that's where you may find a bit more freedom to trade.

A very common question I've been asked over the years about trying to get such jobs is whether they might try to steal your strategies. Imagine having spent years perfecting your trading model and then demonstrating it at a job interview at a hedge fund, only for them to steal your ideas and never give you the job in the first place.

That's not likely to happen. It just doesn't work like that. Not that it would be against some sort of moral code of the hedge fund industry, because that industry isn't all that much into morals in the first place. It just wouldn't make any sense. Any fund or trading company which might be interested in stealing your ideas are amateurs, and you wouldn't want to work for them anyway.

What you have built, no matter how great, isn't likely to be something amazingly revolutionary which will change the direction of the industry. Even if you have come up with something really impressive, it won't be something that someone else can simply pick up and copy. If it was, someone else would already be doing it. No, if you really have come up with some impressive research, it would make a whole lot more sense to simply hire you, to continue to do such research. Trying to steal your work and reverse engineer it would be more costly than to just buy you.

They will try to rip you off, of course, but that's part of the business. They'll try to underpay and overwork you, but not steal your stuff. The concept of the super-secret trading code worth massive amounts of money is largely a myth. It just doesn't work like that. Your code, no matter how great it is, would need to be adapted and fitted into the company's framework, business strategy, customer demands, etc.

And how do you go about getting a job in the financial industry? The same way you get to Carnegie Hall, I suppose. The competition is tough, as it tends to be with anything worthwhile. Perhaps you went to Princeton and your daddy plays golf with Jamie Dimon, but if not, you have some work ahead of you. Find a way to make yourself stand out, to get noticed, or your job application will drown in a sea of thousands of others.